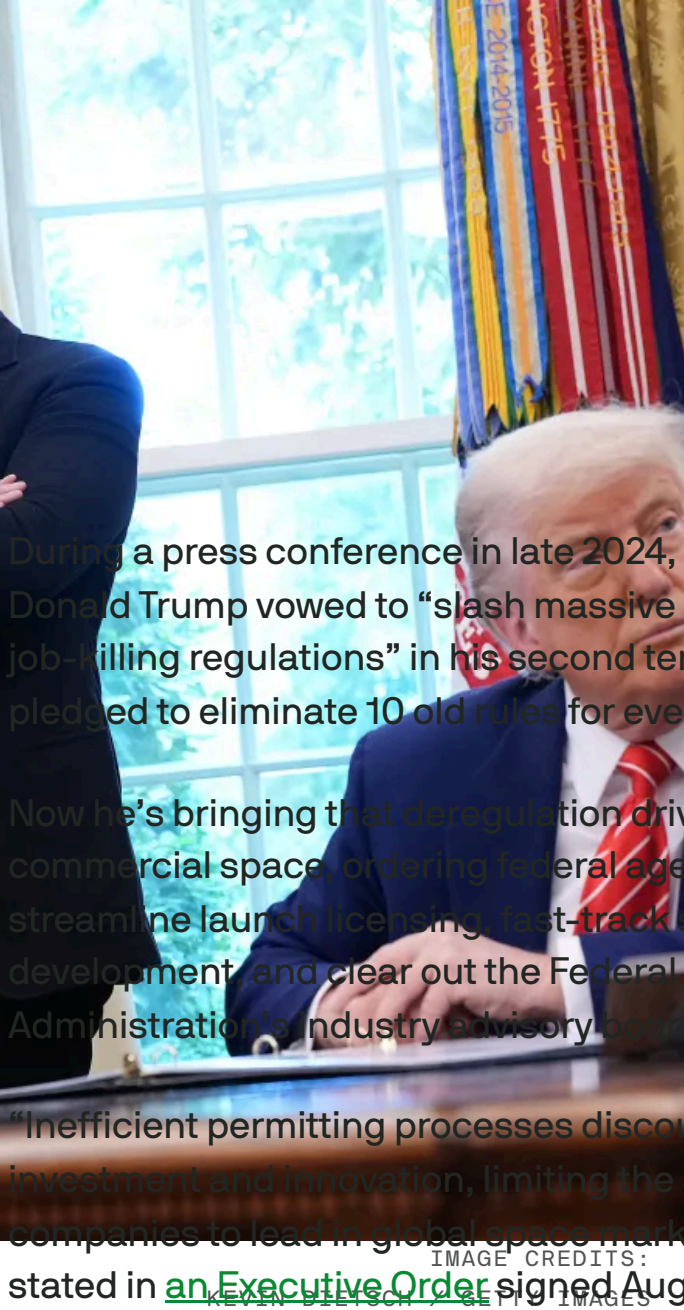


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SPACE



Trump wants to clean up
the space industry's red
tape: Here's who wins



During a press conference in late 2024, President Donald Trump vowed to “slash massive numbers of job-killing regulations” in his second term and pledged to eliminate 10 old rules for every new one.

Now he’s bringing that deregulation drive to commercial space, ordering federal agencies to streamline launch licensing, fast-track spaceport development, and clear out the Federal Aviation Administration’s industry advisory board.

“Inefficient permitting processes discourage investment and innovation, limiting the ability of U.S. companies to lead in global space markets,” he stated in [an Executive Order](#) signed August 13.

IMAGE CREDITS:

KEVIN MAZUR / GETTY IMAGES

The order directs the Department of Transportation (DOT) to cut “outdated, redundant, or overly restrictive” rules that govern launch and reentry licenses. It also instructs the Federal Aviation Administration, which is housed under the DOT, to eliminate or accelerate environmental reviews, ease the path to building new spaceports, and to appoint a “senior executive” charged with fostering “innovation and deregulation.”

The Commerce Department also has been ordered to stand up a new process for authorizing “novel space activities,” like in-space manufacturing or satellite refueling, that don’t fit neatly into existing licensing regimes.

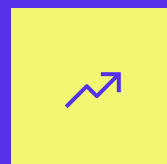
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The executive order came the same day transportation secretary and acting NASA administrator Sean Duffy [dismissed every member](#) of the Commercial Space Transportation Advisory Committee (COMSTAC), a long-standing industry advisory board inside the DOT that shapes spaceflight rules and priorities.

For companies that have spent years mired in environmental reviews and licensing delays, the order was a welcome sign that future bids would experience shorter timelines and more regulatory clarity. The Commercial Space Federation, an industry trade group whose members include SpaceX, Blue Origin, Rocket Lab, and a dozen others, applauded the executive order for providing “regulatory relief to unleash the U.S. commercial space industry.”

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Indeed, commercial players are poised to gain a lot under this new regime. Launch companies could benefit from faster permitting and streamlined

environmental reviews. State-backed spaceport operators, like [Space Florida](#), may also be aided by provisions that accelerate new site development.

Creating a mission authorization framework for “novel” space activities is equally consequential: startups like [Varda Space Industries](#) or Orbit Fab, which are developing technologies to manufacture pharmaceuticals in space and in-orbit refueling, respectively, may gain an advantage by a regulatory approach led by Commerce.

Environmental rule sticking point

Not everyone is celebrating the order. The Center for Biological Diversity (CBD), an environmental group that has challenged the FAA’s approval of SpaceX’s Starship program in Texas, called the order “reckless.”

“Bending the knee to powerful corporations by allowing federal agencies to ignore bedrock environmental laws is incredibly dangerous and puts all of us in harm’s way. This is clearly not in the public interest,” senior attorney Jared Margolis said.

For groups like CBD, environmental reviews are not “overly complex,” as the Order charges — they are often completely insufficient. In 2023, [environmental groups, including the CBD, alleged](#) that the FAA’s environmental assessment of SpaceX’s South Texas plans were inadequate and in violation of the National Environmental Policy Act.

SpaceX has separately waged [an increasingly public campaign](#) against “superfluous” regulations and environmental analyses that have hindered a speedier test campaign.

There are still some unknowns. Legal challenges to the order could slow progress, and the new COMSTAC members, who have yet to be appointed, will inform the future of space rule-making.

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Aria Alamalhodaie covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the public utilities...

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HARDWARE



Nvidia said to be developing new, more powerful AI chip for sale in China

nvidia

Ram Iyer — 5:58 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

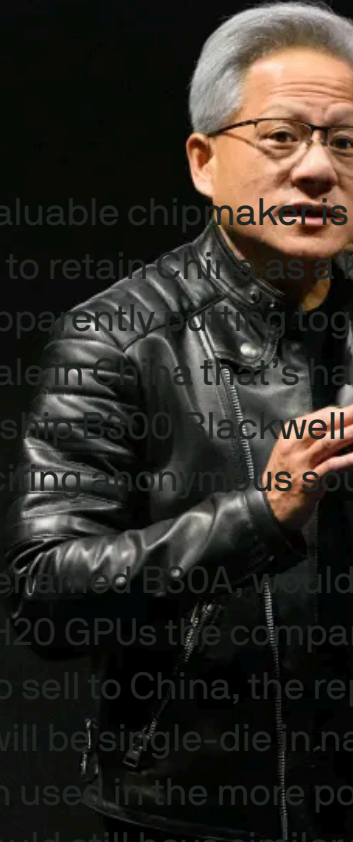


IMAGE CREDITS:

The world's most valuable chipmaker is far from giving up its desire to retain China as a key growth market. Nvidia is apparently putting together a new AI chip meant for sale in China that's half as powerful as its flagship B300 Blackwell GPU, Reuters [reported](#), citing anonymous sources.

This new chip, codenamed B30A, would be more powerful than the H20 GPUs the company is currently allowed to sell to China, the report said, though its design will be single-die in nature, unlike the dual-die design used in the more powerful B300 GPUs. The B30A would still have similar features to the H20, like fast data transmission, support for NVLink, and high-bandwidth memory.

The development of the B30A seems to be separate from [another chip](#) that the company is said to be developing for sale in the country, Reuters reported.

"We evaluate a variety of products for our roadmap, so that we can be prepared to compete to the extent that governments allow. Everything we offer is with the full approval of the applicable authorities and designed solely for beneficial commercial use," Nvidia said in an emailed statement.

The news comes as the Trump administration in recent weeks has [relaxed its stance](#) on letting chipmakers export high-performance AI chips to

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China, though Reuters cited its sources as saying that approvals for this new chip aren't certain at all.

As geopolitical tensions between Beijing and Washington are increasingly affected by the race to develop AI, critics [argue](#) that the U.S. must maintain its lead by controlling the supply of necessary technology to China. But Nvidia and its peers — finding themselves [selling the equivalent of shovels during a gold rush](#) — maintain that ceding the valuable market of China to rivals like Huawei would be tantamount to giving up entirely.

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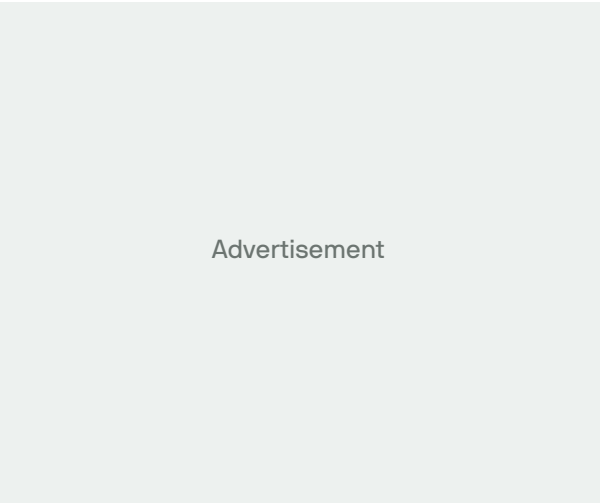
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Ram is a financial and tech reporter and editor. He covered North American and European M&A, equity, regulatory...

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AI crawler Firecrawl
raises \$14.5M, is still

looking to hire agents as employees

Julie Bort — 4:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025



Firecrawl's co-founder and CEO Caleb Pfeffer knew the exact moment he found the investor to lead his Series A.

He was in a coffee meeting with Nexus Venture Partner's Abhishek Sharma at the Blue Bottle in San Francisco's South Park (a favorite VC haunt). While describing the future of the company, he was gesturing so animatedly that his chair tipped over.

"I actually fell out of my chair. And Abhishek, as a great investor does, caught the chair and me as I was falling," Pfeffer described with a laugh. That felt like a symbol for how the founder/investor relationship is supposed to work. "I think that was a clear signal that he was the right partner."

On Tuesday, Firecrawl announced a Series A led by Nexus with participation from Shopify CEO Tobias Lütke and existing investor Y Combinator.

Firecrawl offers a popular open-source web crawler for developers and AI agents, with a commercially supported version available through API. It's used by 350,000 developers, has nearly [50,000 stars](#) on GitHub and its notable customers include Shopify, Replit, and Zapier as well as "some of the largest hedge funds in the world," Pfeffer told TechCrunch. And, he says, the company is already profitable.

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CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

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- 52 minutes ago

STARTUPS



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Julie Bort - 4 hours ago

The startup also just released an API that supports search and will soon add support for natural language prompts, as co-founder and CTO Nicolas Silberstein Camara noted.

Peffer, who co-founded Firecrawl in 2022 with Camara and CMO Eric Ciarla, said gaining Lütke as an investor was “the best kind of validation.”

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They landed him through a gutsy email after discovering the Shopify founder had signed up to try their product through their self-service portal.

“We saw his email come in,” Peffer said. The Firecrawl crew immediately emailed him to welcome him as a customer, but got no response. Two months later, some Shopify folks contacted Firecrawl for an enterprise contract. So Peffer took his shot and emailed Lütke again, mentioning they’d love for him to participate in their upcoming round.

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This time, Lütke responded with compliments about their product. He was in.

While AI web crawlers have [a somewhat dubious reputation these days](#), mostly due to bad actors [that ignore robot.txt files](#), they are also a necessary part of the burgeoning AI world. AI trains on the web, [agents need to access web pages to perform their duties](#), and enterprises need personalized crawlers to consume their own websites for training and operations.

The Firecrawl founders also hope to help address the frustrating parts of their industry. They are working on tools to help website owners, publishers, and other content creators “get paid when AI uses their content. We think this is the way it should be,” Peffer said.

While there have been lots of efforts around this idea from big names like [Adobe and Getty](#) as well as startups [like Bria](#), [Calliope Networks](#), and others, Peffer feels that Firecrawl has an edge because it’s already working with those who are scraping data.

“We already have one side of the marketplace,” he said. “What we want to do is just connect that side of the marketplace to the website owners, the publishers.”

Interestingly, Firecrawl also went viral a few months ago for reasons that have little to do with their open source tool. They had posted an [ad to the YC job board looking to hire an AI agent as an employee for a \\$15,000 salary](#) – perhaps the first job ad for an agent employee, ever.

That job search didn’t yield an agent worth hiring, so Firecrawled upped the budget to up [\\$1 million to hire several agents and the developers who built them, and tried again](#). Applicants flooded in, Peffer said, but the company hasn’t yet hired any. The founders

realized that evaluating and managing wanna-be agent employees is a job in itself. So now they are looking for an AI chief of staff.

Firecrawl's Peffer will [be on stage at Disrupt in October](#) to discuss all that he's learned in a session that covers the pros and cons of hiring AI agents as early employees.

Topics: [AI](#) [AI agents](#) [Startups](#) [TC](#) [Webcrawler](#)

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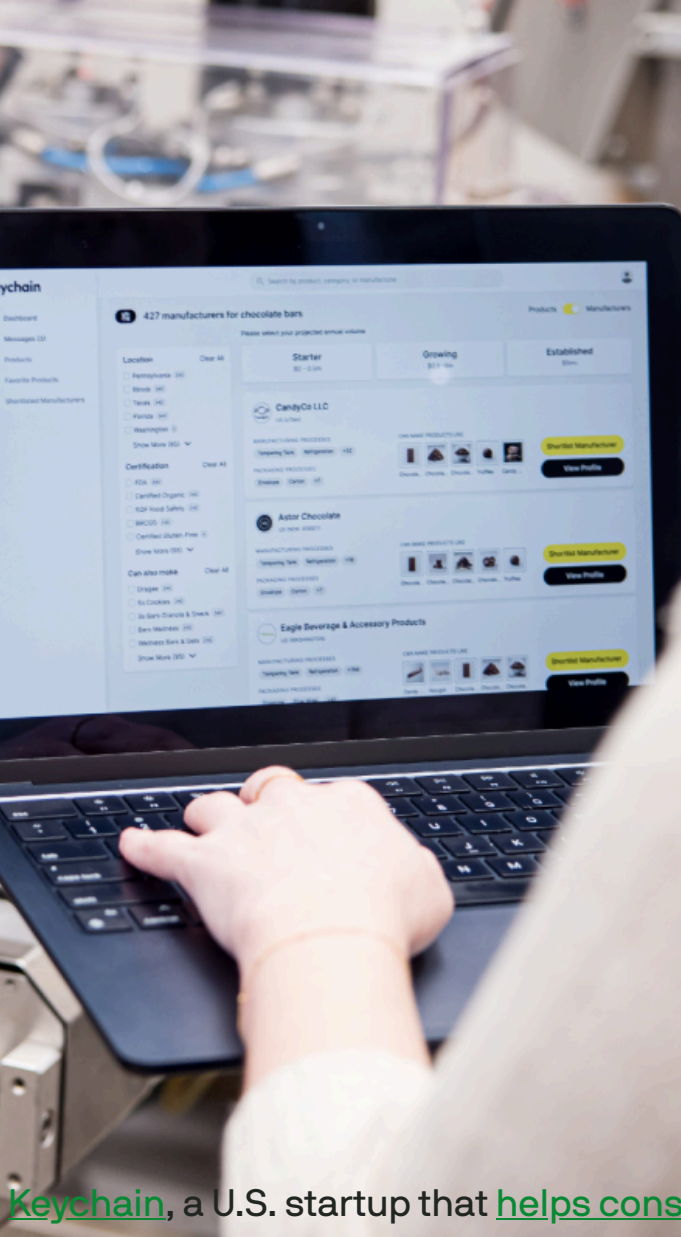
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CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh — 7:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Keychain, a U.S. startup that [helps consumer brands find manufacturing partners](#), has raised \$30 million in fresh funding as it looks to scale its India-based development team to drive growth in North America.

IMAGE CREDIT: KEYCHAIN

While headquartered in New York, Keychain operates as a distributed company with its core engineering and product development centered in India. The startup is doubling down on this model with the new funding, aiming to grow its engineering, product design, and analytics teams in Gurugram from 35 to 70 in the coming months, and to around 100 within a year. This India-based team already represents half of Keychain's 70-person global headcount, with about 20 employees in New York and the remainder in Austin, handling partnerships, go-to-market, and sales.

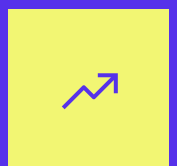
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founder and CEO of Keychain, in an interview.

Hanrahan co-founded Keychain in 2023 with Umang Dua — his co-founder at Handy, a home services software startup later acquired by Angi — and Jordan Weitz. Dua, who is originally from New Delhi, has been a “natural advantage” in building Keychain’s core teams in Gurugram, Hanrahan said.

KEYCHAIN CO-FOUNDERS JORDAN WEITZ, OISIN HANRAHAN, AND UMANG DUA (LEFT TO RIGHT)

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Both Hanrahan and Dua spent time structuring Keychain’s teams across India and the U.S.,

ultimately choosing India as the company's engineering hub. The decision was shaped by their experience at Handy and Angi, where they found it challenging to build a "sustainable, enduring" engineering team in the U.S.

"We've thought about engineering as: how do we build a core, sustainable engineering organization that can get to scale reasonably quickly, that has endurance, that's got deep talent pools, and AI exposure that can take on real, important challenges, that's commercially minded? And we looked at where we had those teams before, when we were at Handy and Angi, and obviously, India is just an amazing location and really checks a lot of those boxes," Hanrahan told TechCrunch.



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Several U.S. startups, [especially those developing SaaS solutions](#), base their engineering and product teams in cities like Bengaluru, Gurugram, and Noida. In recent months, the country has also seen a [wave of multinational companies establishing](#)

[offshore hubs](#), often referred to as global capability centers. But unlike most of these firms — which also target Indian consumers even as many say [India is harder to sell into](#) — Keychain stands apart. It more closely resembles companies like the UK's [Deliveroo](#) and Southeast Asia's [Gojek](#) and [Grab](#) — all of which tap into India's tech talent for product development and R&D without having a market presence in the country.

“India's position as a global technology hub has made it a compelling destination for product development, even for startups that have no direct business in the country,” said Neha Singh, co-founder of the Bengaluru-based private market intelligence platform Tracxn, in an interview with TechCrunch.

India's time zone also allows teams to work beyond U.S. hours, enabling near-continuous development cycles, Singh added.

KeychainOS as the next big thing coming from Indian talent

Keychain plans to use its India team not only to improve its current platform — launched in February 2024 and used by over 20,000 brands and retailers to find manufacturing partners — but also to build new AI-powered software that helps manufacturers manage their product cycles more efficiently and with better oversight.

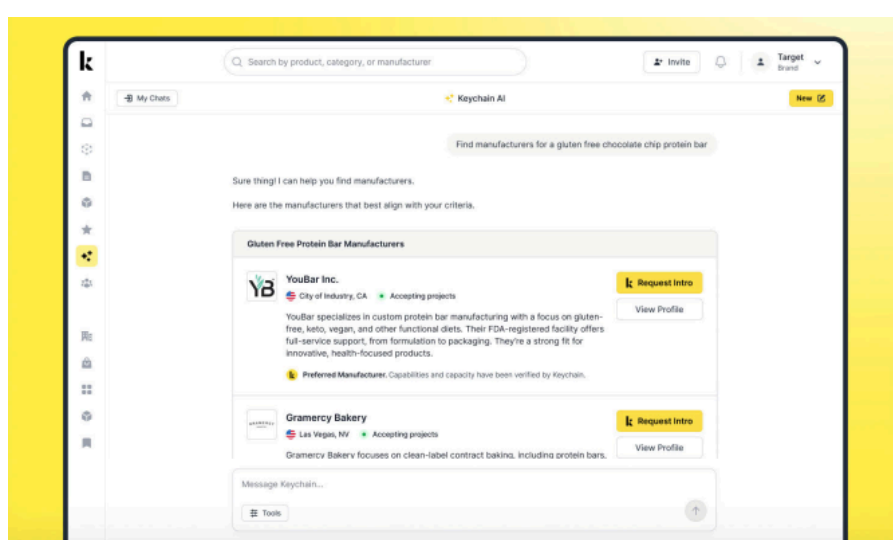
Called KeychainOS, the software will have four modules, with the first one already available. This module helps manufacturers comply with their food safety requirements, using AI to take quantitative data and convert it into a qualitative report that can be shared with auditors. The software can also pull

data using natural language when an auditor requests a specific insight, Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

The other three modules of the software will focus on purchasing and procurement, inventory, and production planning, the executive noted.

The OS offering will compete with traditional ERP systems like Oracle, QAD, and Plex, which require add-ons like TraceGains and Redzone to be usable for manufacturers, the startup said.

In addition to its KeychainOS for manufacturers, Keychain has embedded AI into its search and discovery layer to help retailers quickly find relevant third-party manufacturers for their products.



KEYCHAIN'S SEARCH AND DISCOVERY LAYER WITH AN AI INTEGRATION

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Keychain already helps brands and retailers find third-party manufacturers in food, beverage, supplements, health, and beauty categories and is looking to expand its platform to pet and household products later this year.

Currently, the startup serves businesses in the U.S. and Canada and is [aiming to enter Europe](#) later this year.

While the startup offers its software free to brands and retailers, manufacturers pay to access the platform and get discovered. KeychainOS provides them with another reason to engage.

Keychain already has over 30,000 manufacturers on its platform, with “hundreds and hundreds” paying to use it. These customers pay anywhere from \$10,000 to over \$100,000, Hanrahan said, adding that the startup earns around \$20,000 per manufacturer annually on average.

Keychain’s Series B round was led by Wellington Management and existing investor BoxGroup, alongside other existing investors. With this funding, the startup has raised \$68 million in total. Of that, Hanrahan told TechCrunch that the startup still has over \$50 million in the bank.

The startup had a post-money valuation of \$260 million in its last round of \$15 million in November 2024. Hanrahan did not disclose the current valuation but said it was a “good step up.”

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Jagmeet Singh

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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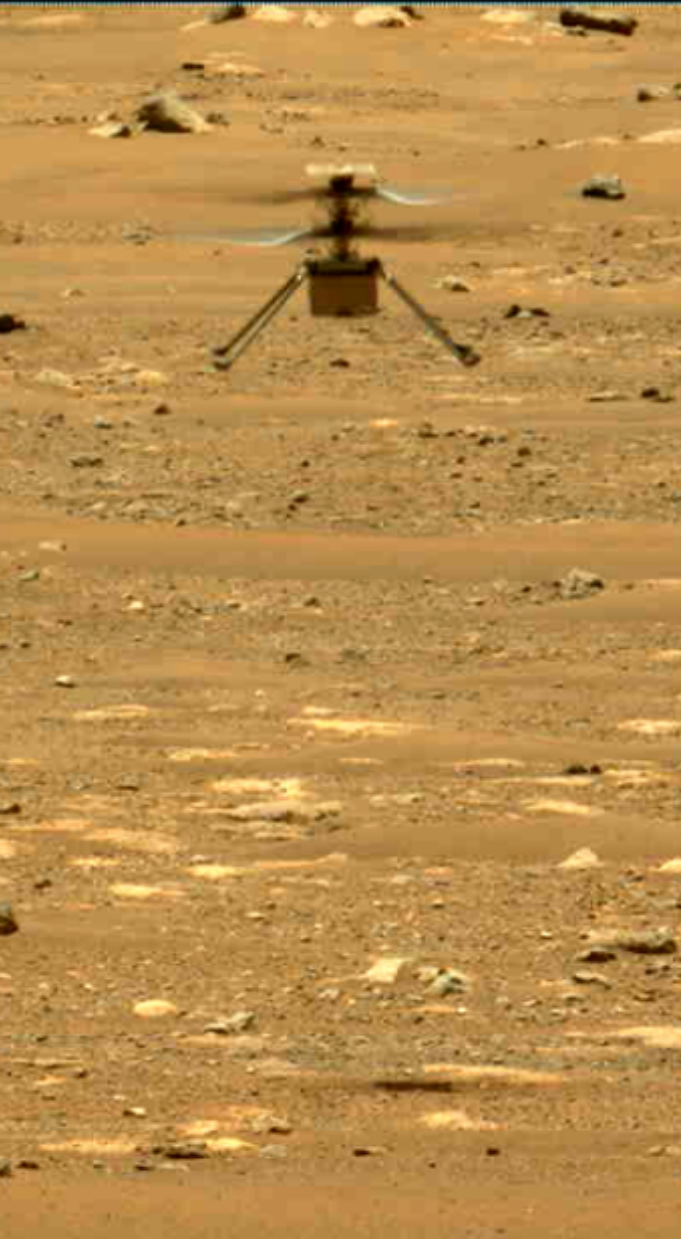


IMAGE CREDITS: NASA/JPL-CALTECH/ASU/MSSS

SPACE



NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars

Aria Alamalhodaei — 10:26 AM PDT · August 13, 2025

For decades, NASA built and flew its own relay orbiters and spacecraft to ferry valuable data back to Earth. Now the agency is shifting to buying connectivity as a service, much like it does for launch and astronaut transport.

That pivot has sparked a race, with major contenders pitching ways to keep Mars missions online. What's at stake isn't a single contract: it's the data pipe to Mars.

This new approach, which will mix NASA assets and commercial infrastructure, would gradually replace the patchwork relay network the agency relies on

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today. Generally, that works by orbiters like Mars Reconnaissance Orbiter and MAVEN that pick up data from rovers and landers and transmit it to the Deep Space Network's (DSN) giant antennas on Earth.

NASA's relay spacecraft are still healthy, but they were never meant to be a permanent backbone. The [agency's latest senior review](#) on planetary missions calls out MAVEN's critical role as a relay and provides steps to keep it available into the early 2030s. But eventually, this hardware will decay.

At the same time, NASA's Space Communications and Navigation (SCaN) program, which manages the DSN, is looking for solutions to augment these aging assets. The aim, according to an RFP released in July and due today, is to create an interoperable marketplace where NASA can be one of many customers instead of the owner-operator.

The current request is specifically for capability studies, not immediate hardware buys. The ask is twofold: a "lunar trunkline" between the moon and Earth and end-to-end Mars communications that move data from assets on the surface, through Mars orbit, and to operations centers on Earth.

It's a formidable challenge. Any architecture must contend with the vast distance between Earth and the moon and Mars, long latency, periodic solar interference and Earth visibility windows, and high requirements for fault-tolerant systems. That's why NASA is asking for plans, to gauge how industry might solve these puzzles, rather than immediately jumping to procurement.

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While TechCrunch can't confirm which companies are submitting concept proposals, a handful have already staked their place in the race.

Blue Origin [just unveiled](#) a Mars Telecommunications Orbiter built on its Blue Ring platform, pitched as maneuverable, high-performance spacecraft to support NASA missions to Mars as soon as 2028. Rocket Lab has touted its own Mars telecom orbiter concept, [which the company says](#) is a core element of its proposed architecture for the Mars Sample Return campaign.

In 2024, NASA's Mars Exploration Program [separately funded 12 short commercial services studies](#), including a trio of studies for next-gen relay services, to SpaceX, Lockheed Martin, and Blue Origin. SpaceX's proposal to "adapt Earth-orbit communication satellites for Mars" will likely be derived from its Starlink internet satellite constellation.

The long-term goal is to transform the agency's planetary exploration agenda from pure-science missions to a permanent human presence on the moon and, eventually, on Mars.



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